

6 Advani's Rath Yatra, December 1990

In March 1990, INDIA TODAY did a story on L.K. Advani that called him a saffron seer. He undertook the phenomenal Rath Yatra in 1990 that was to change the course of the BJP and make it a strong contender for power. In May 1991, INDIA TODAY noted, "By unprecedented cadre mobilisation, playing the Ayodhya card and enticing voters to gamble on an untried party, the BJP hopes to dramatically improve its Lok Sabha strength and in L. K. Advani, the party, for the first time, has a national level prime ministerial candidate. In perhaps the most ambitious grassroots mobilisation that any party has ever undertaken, almost the entire network of RSS-affiliated organisations throughout India is moving into the electoral fray with the well-oiled cohesiveness of a conquering army." Finally, the BJP had arrived.



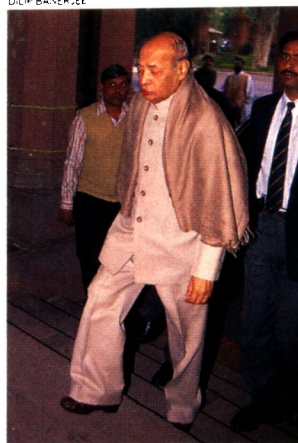
8 Rao chooses Manmohan as FM, July 1991

P.V. Narasimha's choice of Manmohan Singh as the finance minister was the biggest surprise of 1991. "Here is something Rajiv Gandhi forgot to do as prime minister. He talked about taking India into the 21st century, but forgot all about the present one... Rao and his finance minister got it just right" (INDIA TODAY, August 1992).

9 Sonia rejects post of PM, May 2004

In one smart stroke, Sonia Gandhi managed to silence her opponents and strengthen her dynasty. "It was a no that shook India. Sonia's decision not to be the prime minister was a strategic renunciation that blinds the Sangh Parivar's attacks and enhances her stature as a leader" (INDIA TODAY, May 2004).

DILIP BANERJEE



7 Rao becomes PM, June 1991

"With no big leader heading the government, no one expects miracles," noted INDIA TODAY in July 1991.

P.V. Narasimha Rao had nearly retired from active politics and it was Rajiv Gandhi's assassination that brought him back. The opportunity to lead the country came as a surprise not only for him, but for the whole nation. "He checkmated his opponents, moulded the Congress into a different animal and emerged as its undisputed leader" (INDIA TODAY, April 1992).

catchy political party slogans

"Work More Talk Less"

Coined by Indira Gandhi, when she came to office in 1966.

"Indira Hatao Desh Bachao"

By Jayaprakash Narayan for the 1977 general elections.

"Ek sherni, sau langoor, Chikmagalur, Chikmagalur."

By Devraj Urs, for Indira Gandhi's by-election in 1978.

"Dalit-Muslim Bhai Bhai"

A Mandal Commission slogan of 1981, used by Hindutva forces.

"Jab tak suraj chand rahega, Indira tera naam rahega."

Coined for 1984 elections after Mrs Gandhi's assassination.

"Hum saugandh Ram ki khat hain, mandir wahin banayenge."

The BJP's chant in 1989 which led it to a stupendous victory.

"Bari, bari, sab ki bari, ab ki bari, Atal Bihari."

BJP's slogan at a Lucknow election rally in March 1996.

"Jaat par na pat par, mohar lagegi haath par."

P.V. Narasimha Rao coined this slogan for the 1996 elections.

"India Shining"

Coined by Pramod Mahajan, BJP used it for the 2004 general elections. It boomeranged.

by Gunjeet K. Sra